

2%

Approximate increase in allocation for the health and family welfare ministry, from ₹89,155 crore in 2023-24 to ₹90,958.6 crore for 2024-25

SURGICAL STRIDE

A surgeon inspects the installing of a laser brain surgery machine at Apollo Hospital Delhi in March

HIGHLIGHTS

- **Marginal to zero increase in budget of National Health Mission and Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission**
- **14% increase in allocation for health research department — Rs 3,301.73 crore, up from Rs 2,892.83 crore in 2023-24**
- **Proposed changes in the basic customs duty for X-ray tubes and flat panel detectors will benefit domestic original equipment manufacturers, but appears misdirected as many healthcare and wellness centres still lack basic diagnostic tools**
- **No incentives for skilling and increasing number of frontline health workers, which was expected by many experts**

has been repeatedly promised by the government over the past two years. In FY 2023, healthcare accounted for 2.1 per cent of GDP expenditure. According to national health accounts, between 2013–14 and 2019–20, the increase in government health expenditure's share in GDP was a mere 0.22 per cent.

Not only are many expected healthcare reforms missing in the 2024-25 budget, but the measly increase in funds allocation has raised doubts about the future of schemes which were announced in the interim budget earlier this year. For example, the National Health Mission (NHM) is set to roll out a nationwide cervical cancer vaccination programme. Universal immunisation for children, an NHM programme, still stands at 85 per cent. The July 23 budget announced a tribal health scheme, which too will have to be implemented by NHM. But despite the rising burden of public health schemes on the agency, the NHM received just a 1.16 per cent increase in funds allocation over last year's revised estimates. And despite promises of promoting digital health in India, the Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission, implemented by the National Health Authority (NHA, attached to the health ministry), has had no increase in budget allocation from the revised estimates for 2023-24. In comparison, the government's flagship medical insurance scheme, Ay-